

Earwax - Male (Adult)

Algorithm 1401 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Male

Definition

- Qatar-localized UAT-only adult and pediatric pathway for suspected earwax, screening for sudden hearing loss, infection, perforation, foreign body and contraindications to irrigation or drops.
- Adult patient.
- Male.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the blockage been present?
2. [YES_NO] Any pain, discharge, or bleeding from the ear?
3. [OPEN_TEXT] Has anything already been tried, including drops, irrigation, candles or cotton buds?
4. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the exact age; is the patient pregnant; and are there sudden hearing loss, pain, discharge, bleeding, dizziness, previous perforation/surgery, tubes, diabetes, immune suppression, foreign body or safeguarding concerns?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Earache

Is ear pain, discharge, fever, or acute illness the main concern rather than wax blockage?

Ear pain or acute ear illness belongs in the Earache pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Have symptoms lasted more than 5 days despite home treatment, or is there a severe blockage preventing hearing?

NHS.UK earwax guidance recommends primary-care review for symptoms lasting more than 5 days or a severe hearing blockage.

1. Disposition level 50

Is this a recent, mild earwax blockage with none of the features above?

NHS.UK guidance recommends softening oil drops as first-line home treatment.

Advice

Urgent earwax review

- Arrange review by a primary-care clinician or nurse - the wax may need professional removal by irrigation, microsuction, or gentle scraping.
- Call Back If: pain or discharge develops.

Assessment before earwax treatment

- Do not insert objects, use ear candles or irrigate the ear. Arrange clinician/pharmacist review before drops are selected because age, eardrum status, surgery/tubes, infection, pregnancy and allergies must be checked.
- Call Back If: sudden hearing loss; pain, discharge, bleeding, fever or dizziness.

First aid

References

- NHS.UK, "Earwax build-up", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/earwax-build-up/> (page last reviewed 05 January 2024)

Provenance

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